

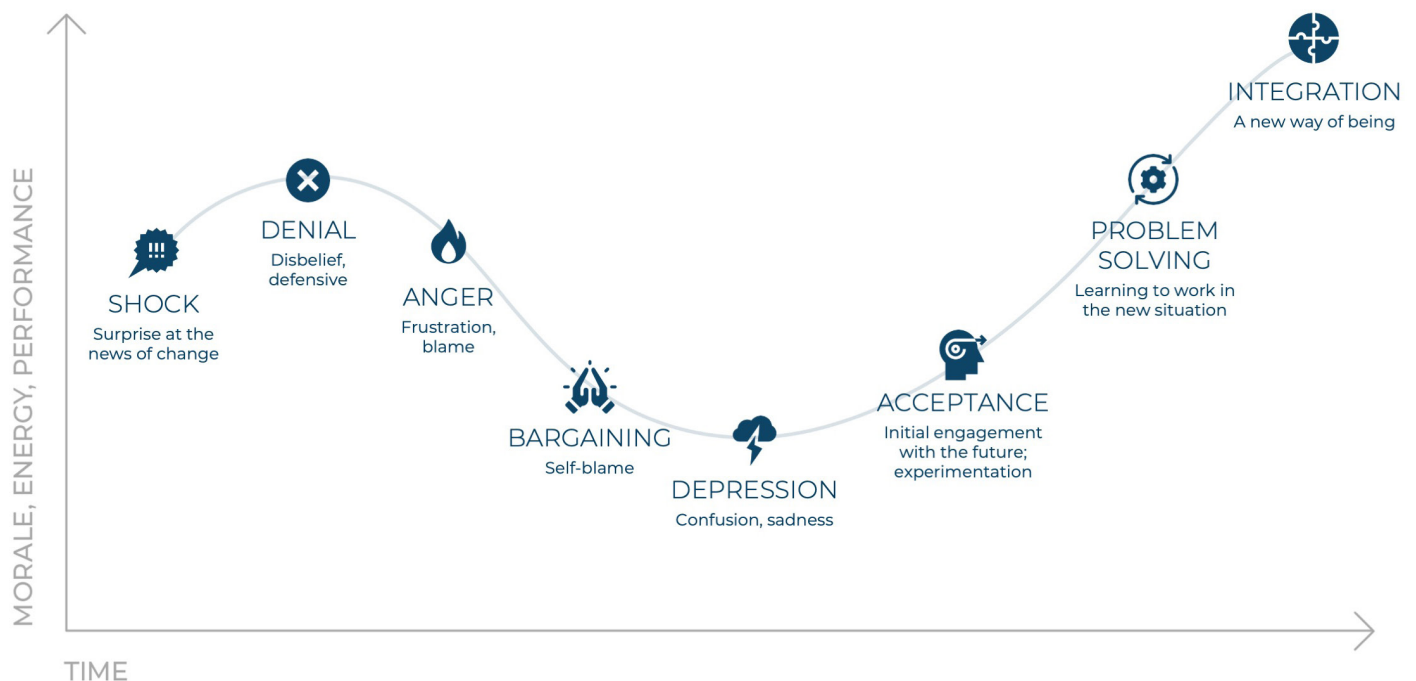


ADAPTING TO CHANGE

Emotions During a Change Event

The Kubler-Ross Change model was originally developed by Elisabeth Kubler-Ross and was based on a 5-stage model of grief; shock/denial, anger, bargaining, depression and acceptance. The model has been subsequently modified and extended to address the stage of emotion that people experience in their lives or in the workplace during a major change event.

To navigate change effectively, as individuals we need to move through the stages quickly to acceptance, and as leaders we need to be aware of the different stages and support people throughout the process moving from a current state to a future state environment.



Source; Adapted from Kubler-Ross 1969



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Emotional Response to Change – The Key Stages.

The 5 stages as originally defined by Kubler-Ross are summarised below, together with additional steps in the change journey where we end up fully integrated in the new way of being or working.



Shock

The cycle begins with a shock, some unexpected news, perhaps an announcement at work relating to an organisational change, redundancies, or merger. This can be destabilising for the individual and negative thoughts often creep in relating to the potential impact it may have on them.



Denial

In this stage, emotions often move to thinking that the specific change is not going to happen, and 'won't affect me' if it does. It's not uncommon for people to carry on as if nothing has happened, ignoring the potential consequences of the change. It's typical for productivity and performance to decline at this point as people find comfort in clinging to the old way of working, losing sight of reality along the way.



Anger

As the pending change finally sinks in, emotions often turn to anger or fear. Fear of what the change might bring at an individual level, fear of losing one's job or status, or simply fear of the unknown. Anger can surface as people don't always buy 14 into the reasons for change. At this point the change initiative has the potential to spiral out of control if not addressed and productivity and motivation plummets.



Bargaining

Once individuals move out of the 'anger' stage they often attempt to delay the change or propose an easier and more comfortable alternative for themselves. Often this involves trying to negotiate an alternative and find a compromise.



Depression

In this stage, individuals lose hope and there are clear signs of negativity, sadness, regret and demotivation. This impacts productivity and performance as enthusiasm and engagement are at an all-time low.



Acceptance

At this point, individuals come to terms with the change and start to think about the opportunities that may arise as a result of the change, exploring new ways of working in the new model. With any change it's important to move through the stages to 'acceptance' as quickly as possible.



Problem Solving/Integration

As people start to explore the new opportunities that change may bring, they may start to learn new skills and experiment with new ways of working in the new environment. Motivation, enthusiasm and productivity continue to rise. In the final stage of the change process, the individual has become fully aligned with the new way of working and motivation and productivity levels return or exceed previous levels prior to the change event.



Navigating Change



For a major change event, write down the following. Use the change curve to assist you;



Describe the change event.



What impact will it have on you and your loved ones?



How do you feel?



What are the potential new opportunities that the change may bring?



What new skills might you be able to learn?



Who has already embraced the change and what benefits did they see?



Where are you now on the change curve?



How can you accelerate through to acceptance and beyond?



What specific actions can you take?



ADAPTING TO CHANGE | BEST PRACTICE

Navigating Change



Focus on the things you can control and move quickly through the change curve to acceptance and beyond.



Look for solutions not problems and reframe negative thoughts into positive actions.



Seek guidance from others who have positively embraced the change.



Set yourself specific goals to help you get to acceptance more quickly.



Consider how you can turn adversity into opportunity.



Take a risk, get out of your comfort zone, challenge yourself and learn from the experience.



Be flexible in your thinking, don't become entrenched in your habitual perspective.



Focus on the opportunity for personal growth and the opportunity to learn new skills.